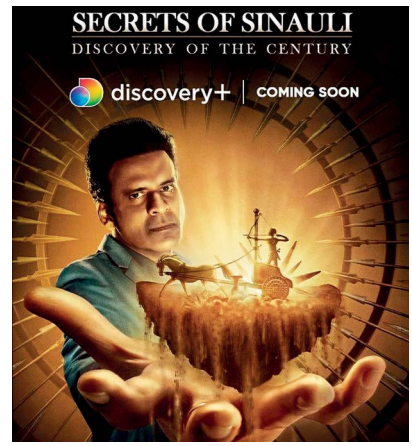




just authentic information but also wants it to be told in a cinematic and entertaining way. That entails roping in not just academics, researchers and experts but also celebs like Amish Tripathi (*Legends of the Ramayana*) and actors Maniesh Paul (*History Hunter*) and Manoj Bajpayee (*Secrets of Sinauli* and *Secrets of the Kohinoor*) to host tell-all series.

SUCH A LONG JOURNEY

Making these shows, though, is no cakewalk. Time is the most precious resource. Pre-production entails rigorous research which, depending on the project, can take 3-6 months. In the case of celebrity bare-it-all shows, the wait is longer for approvals from subjects. India Today Originals' [a film production arm of India Today Group] *Curry & Cyanide* took three and a half years before it saw the light of day on Netflix. "A documentary series has more challenges than a fiction show will ever have," says Chandni Ahlawat Dabas, business head, originals & special projects, at the group. Interviewees can drop out at the nth hour and there's mountains of legal paperwork, including appearance releases. For Dabas, unscripted content in streaming is entering "Phase 2", which is ushering a gamut of changes. "Content-wise, platforms are now interested in marquee projects; the stories have to be the bigger ones," she says. "They are grappling with conversations like 'if we have 20 crores for a project, should we spend it on a fiction show or on a documentary that may not have the same number of eyeballs'," she adds.

Samira Kanwar, vice president, content, VICE APAC, one of the first to get into developing unscripted content back in 2019, is feeling the impact of Phase 2 too. The first five years, she says, saw non-fiction "grow by leaps and bounds" largely due to the fact that "experimentation" was encouraged. It saw VICE create true crime documentaries such as three instalments of Netflix's Indian Predator series as well as off-the-beaten track titles such as *Rainbow Rishta* and *Cinema Marte Dum Tak* for Prime. But there's a long way to go before you can catch up with the West in storytelling, Kanwar adds. "Now, we are reaching a point where platforms are pulling back to take stock of what works and what doesn't.... When there are budget cuts in entertainment, non-fiction is the first to take a hit."

Kanwar believes there are two kinds of unscripted non-fiction content being made. On one end are insightful documentaries that win acclaim and accolades [*Rainbow Rishta* was recently nominated for outstanding documentary at the GLAAD Media award], on the other are titles that click. "Those two are at odds with each other," she says. But few rules are etched in gold. True crime and autobiographical/celeb documentaries get first preference as audiences also like them. "Fact is stranger than fiction, and interesting, untold stories that can hold a candle to fiction," Kanwar says, "will always find favour."

Audiences want facts told in a cinematic way. Hence, roping in the likes of Amish Tripathi and Manoj Bajpayee to host tell-all series



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A GROWING ECOSYSTEM

Making binge-worthy documentaries requires a new crew, as distinct from that found on a fiction series set. For Amazon Prime's *wedding. con*, BBC Studios roped in a therapist to ensure the emotional needs of the five women—victims of betrayal and financial fraud—were tended to as they opened up about their trauma on camera for the first time. VICE Studios put its crew through sensitivity training before and as they went about following the LGBTQI+ people featured in *Rainbow Rishta*. Documentary-makers who rely on a talking-heads format